month, these men, ‘both high and low’, had moved forward, step by coordinated step, pressing animals into grounds as ‘capacious [as the] hearts of princes’.[56]

When the qamargah was ready, Akbar rode in with only one man by his side, Aziz, Shamsuddin Ataka’s son and Akbar’s favourite milk brother. The two friends hunted their fill for five days, Akbar aiming ‘the arrow, the sword, the lance and the musket’, swinging lassos to catch ‘lightning-footed deer’.[57] The rest of the nobility was camped on the qamargah’s borders, watching to see that no animal escaped in the day, keeping guard with flaming torches at night.

When Akbar was satisfied, the nobility had their turn, and so down the ranks to the foot soldiers until every man had taken what life he was entitled to, and all turned their backs on the blood-soaked plain.

It was an extravagance of gore, the sheer spectacle of which suggests that Akbar had not come all the way from Agra to Punjab for a hunt.

He had come to frighten his little brother.

~

Mirza Muhammad Hakim, over a decade Akbar’s junior, was an infant when Humayun left Kabul to recover his home in Hindustan – and never returned. He was brought up, therefore, by his mother, Mahchuchak (‘Moonflower’) Begum, whose dramatic and tragic struggle to ensure her son a throne deserves to be better known.

Humayun had left Kabul in Munim Khan’s charge; and, as long as Bairam Khan held sway over Akbar’s throne, the Chagatai nobleman remained where he was. During Bairam’s ouster, however, when Akbar summoned his old ataliq across the Indus, Munim left Kabul in charge of his son, Ghazi Khan.

Ghazi Khan was not a popular administrator; or, perhaps, Mahchuchak had had enough of being supervised by her stepson’s aides. One day, he returned from touring some melon fields outside Kabul only to find the city gates locked against him – giving Abul Fazl the chance to quote an apt proverb: ‘Eat the melons, what business have you with their beds?’

Sheepishly Ghazi Khan rode off to Hindustan; and Mahchuchak ‘undertook the affairs of Kabul’.[58]